

SETUP INSTRUCTIONS

Below OP — Twilio WhatsApp Setup

End-to-end automation for WhatsApp lead capture and subscriber alerts

Date	22 May 2026
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Total time	30 minutes for sandbox · 24–48 hours total including Meta approval
Cost	Free trial credit on signup (\$15) · ~\$5/month for our expected volume after that

1. Why we need Twilio

The Below OP platform already runs Telegram end-to-end: real listings ingest from Apify, the broker-canonical alert posts to @DubaiPropertydeal automatically, and leads from the public site DM to Rami in under a second. That covers Telegram subscribers and gives us full automation on one channel.

Twilio adds WhatsApp 1:1 messaging. This is needed for three things:

- Lead-capture inquiries automatically WhatsApp Rami at +971585276222 (in addition to Telegram DM).
- Opted-in public subscribers who picked WhatsApp on /alerts receive personalised alerts on their phone.
- Approved WhatsApp Business templates let us legally broadcast price-drop alerts within Meta's rules.

Important context: Twilio cannot post to a WhatsApp Channel (like @DubaiPropertydeal). Channels are a Meta consumer feature with no API. The Channel will remain manual via the /admin/relay tool. Twilio handles 1:1 direct messages only.

2. The two paths

There are two stages to setting up Twilio WhatsApp. Both can run in parallel.

Sandbox (today)	Production (24–48h)
Free, instant, anyone who texts the "join <code>" phrase can receive messages. Limited to numbers that have opted into the sandbox. Useful for proving the integration end-to-end before Meta approval.	Verified business sender + Meta-approved templates. Can message any opted-in WhatsApp user without the "join" step. Required before public launch.

Recommended order

Do Phase A and Phase B today (30 min). Confirm with Rami it works end-to-end against your own number. Then start Phase C (production sender + templates) and let it bake the 24–48 hours Meta requires for approval.

Phase A — Create the Twilio account

Time: ~5 minutes.

1. Go to <https://www.twilio.com/try-twilio> and sign up with your work email.
2. Verify the email Twilio sends you.
3. Verify your phone number (Twilio will SMS a code).
4. On the welcome questionnaire, pick: Use case = "Alerts & Notifications", Code or no-code = "With code", Language = "Node.js" (any answer is fine — these just personalise the docs).
5. You will land on the Twilio Console at <https://console.twilio.com>. On the right side of the console homepage you will see your **Account SID** and **Auth Token** under "Account Info". Note these down — you will send them to Rami at the end.

Phase B — Activate the WhatsApp Sandbox

Time: ~3 minutes.

1. In the left sidebar, click **Messaging** → **Try it out** → **Send a WhatsApp message**.
2. Twilio shows you a sandbox phone number (typically **+1 415 523 8886**) and a unique join code (e.g. `join green-house`).
3. Open WhatsApp on your phone, start a chat with +1 415 523 8886, send the join code as a message. Twilio replies "Twilio Sandbox: You are all set!".
4. Have Rami do the same from his number +971 58 527 6222. This opts him into the sandbox so our `/api/leads` route can WhatsApp him.
5. From the same Twilio sandbox screen, copy down the "From" number (e.g. `whatsapp:+14155238886`). You will send this to Rami too.

Sandbox limitations

Sandbox only works for numbers that have texted the join code. You cannot use it to message any random WhatsApp user. That is what Phase C unlocks. Sandbox is also free indefinitely, so leave it active even after production goes live as a fallback for testing.

Phase C — Set up the production WhatsApp Business sender

Time: ~30 minutes of your time + 24–48 hours of Meta review SLA.

C.1 — Verify your business with Twilio

1. In the Twilio Console, go to **Account** → **General Settings** → **Business Profile**.
2. Fill in the legal business name (Emerge Digital, or whatever the entity is for Below OP), website (<https://belowop-demo.vercel.app>), business address (UAE — Dubai), business email, and primary contact.
3. Submit. Twilio reviews internally — usually a few hours, sometimes same day.

C.2 — Register a WhatsApp sender

1. Go to **Messaging** → **Senders** → **WhatsApp senders** → **New WhatsApp sender**.
2. Pick "Use my existing phone number". Use the broker number +971 58 527 6222 if Rami agrees, or a separate dedicated number.
3. **Important:** the number must not currently be registered on the WhatsApp consumer app. If +971 58 527 6222 is already on WhatsApp, Rami will need to either uninstall WhatsApp on that number first or pick a different number.
4. Submit. Twilio relays the application to Meta. Meta SLA is 24–48 hours but often resolves in 12 hours.

C.3 — Submit three message templates for Meta approval

While the sender is in review, prepare these three templates. Each must be Meta-approved separately. Submit them all at once. Go to **Messaging** → **Content Builder** → **New content template**.

Template 1: TPL_BELOWOP_LISTING (Category: Marketing)

Use case: notify a subscriber of a brand-new below-OP unit matching their filters.

```
🔴 *Below OP — New Listing*

📍 *{{1}}*

• *{{2}}*
• ~*{{3}} sqft*~ | ~*{{4}} sqm*~
• *{{5}}*
```

```
*Developer*: {{6}}
```

```
*Selling Price*: *{{7}} AED* 🔥  
{{8}}
```

```
For serious inquiries reply to this message or contact Wa.me/{{9}}
```

Variables: {{1}} project + community, {{2}} unit type, {{3}} sqft, {{4}} sqm, {{5}} feature line, {{6}} developer, {{7}} price in M, {{8}} optional handover or payment line, {{9}} broker WhatsApp number.

Template 2: TPL_BELOWOP_PRICEDROP (Category: Marketing)

Use case: notify a subscriber that a previously seen unit dropped further below its first-tracked price.

```
🔴 *Below OP — PRICE DROP*
```

```
📌 *{{1}}*
```

```
*{{2}}% DROP detected*
```

- *{{3}}*
- ~*{{4}} sqft*~ | ~*{{5}} sqm*~
- *{{6}}*

```
*Developer*: {{7}}
```

```
*New Price*: *{{8}} AED* 🔥
```

```
*Was*: ~*{{9}} AED*~
```

```
For serious inquiries reply to this message or contact Wa.me/{{10}}
```

```
Reply STOP to unsubscribe.
```

Variables: {{1}} project + community, {{2}} drop percentage, {{3}} unit type, {{4}} sqft, {{5}} sqm, {{6}} feature line, {{7}} developer, {{8}} new price, {{9}} previous price, {{10}} broker WhatsApp number.

Template 3: TPL_BELOWOP_LEAD (Category: Utility)

Use case: notify Rami when a buyer submits an inquiry on the website. Internal-facing; Utility category requires no opt-in.

```
*New Below OP lead*
```

```
*Name*: {{1}}
```

```
*Phone*: {{2}}  
*Listing*: {{3}}  
*Price*: AED {{4}}  
*Message*: {{5}}
```

```
Open: {{6}}
```

Variables: {{1}} buyer name, {{2}} buyer phone, {{3}} listing project + ref, {{4}} listing price, {{5}} optional buyer message, {{6}} link back to the listing on belowop-demo.vercel.app.

Template approval timing

Meta typically returns a verdict within 24 hours per template. Marketing templates sometimes need one revision (Meta is strict about CTA text, emojis at start, all-caps). If rejected, the rejection reason is shown in the Twilio console — adjust and resubmit.

Phase D — Send credentials back to Rami

Once Phase A and Phase B are complete (you do not need to wait for Phase C), reply to Rami on WhatsApp with these five values:

Value	Where to find it
TWILIO_ACCOUNT_SID	Console home → Account Info (starts with AC...)
TWILIO_AUTH_TOKEN	Console home → Account Info → Show
TWILIO_WHATSAPP_FROM	Sandbox: <code>whatsapp:+14155238886</code> — Production: <code>whatsapp:+971585276222</code> (or your verified sender)
LEADS_NOTIFY_WHATSAPP	Rami's personal WhatsApp: <code>whatsapp:+971585276222</code>
Sandbox join code (if applicable)	e.g. <code>join green-house</code> — so Rami can opt in from his number

Rami will set these as environment variables on Vercel and redeploy. From that point, every lead submitted on `belowop-demo.vercel.app` will WhatsApp Rami within seconds.

Phase E — Verification

Once Rami confirms the env vars are live on Vercel, do this two-minute end-to-end test:

1. Open `belowop-demo.vercel.app` on your phone.
2. Tap any listing row → the lead modal opens.
3. Enter your name, your WhatsApp number, tick consent, submit.
4. Within 10 seconds, Rami should receive a WhatsApp message with your inquiry details.
5. Reply to Rami's WhatsApp to confirm receipt.

That confirms the full chain: web → Postgres → Twilio → Rami. Once that works, the same code path will fire automatically for every lead from real buyers.

Frequently asked questions

Will this cost money?

Twilio gives a \$15 trial credit at signup. Each WhatsApp message via Twilio costs \$0.005 to \$0.05 depending on the conversation type. For our expected volume (under 100 leads per month at launch, growing to maybe 500), spend is ~\$2–5/month. Far below the broker margin on a single inquiry that converts.

What if Meta rejects the templates?

Most common reasons: starting with an emoji, "click here" CTAs, false urgency. Twilio shows the rejection reason. Edit the template text in the Content Builder and resubmit — usually approved on the second pass within 24 hours.

Can we test the templates before Meta approves them?

Yes. The sandbox supports free-form messages (not template-bound) so you can send anything to numbers that joined the sandbox. Once templates are approved, we switch to template-bound sends and the sandbox restriction lifts.

What if the broker number cannot be used?

You can buy a dedicated Twilio number for \$1.15/month in the same Console under Phone Numbers → Buy a number → United Arab Emirates. That number will be the Below OP broker-of-record number for outbound WhatsApp.

How do we unsubscribe people?

Twilio auto-handles "STOP" replies — the user is opted out of further Marketing-category messages from our sender. The /alerts opt-in flow on the website is the legal opt-in record we keep.

Is RERA needed before Twilio goes live?

Yes, eventually. RERA registration is a separate launch-blocker for the public site (we present listings as broker inventory). Twilio setup can proceed in parallel — they're independent paths.

What's next after Twilio is live

Once Phase D credentials are in and Phase E verification passes:

- Lead inquiries from the website automatically WhatsApp Rami.
- Subscribers who picked WhatsApp on /alerts will start receiving template-bound alerts as soon as templates are Meta-approved.
- Rami can decide whether to expand to broader public marketing (template-bound campaigns) or keep it 1:1 inquiry-driven.

Telegram remains the primary public broadcast surface; WhatsApp Channel posts manually via /admin/relay; Twilio handles direct WhatsApp 1:1. **Three surfaces, all integrated.**

Questions? WhatsApp Rami on +971 58 527 6222.